

Tauris Skills

Claude Cowork Installation Guide

For new users installing on their own machine — including locked-down / no-admin setups

This guide installs the Tauris skills (and, optionally, the PHDWin v2 MCP server) into Claude Cowork. It is written for someone setting up on a fresh machine. The skills install requires **no admin rights, no Python, and no special drive locations** — everything lives inside your own user folder.

1. What you're installing

There are two independent pieces. You can install just the skills, or the skills plus the MCP server.

Piece	What it needs
Skills (4 of them)	Just file-copying into your user profile. No admin, no Python, no drivers. Works on locked-down machines.
PHDWin v2 MCP server (optional)	Python + the fastmcp package. Native PHDWin (.phz) extraction also needs the 32-bit Clarion/TopSpeed ODBC driver (admin install). SQLite-only review does not.

Recommendation: install the skills first (Section 3) and confirm they work. Add the MCP server (Section 4) only if you need the PHDWin inspection and conversion tools.

2. You do not need C:\Dev or any special location

Some examples in the repo show a path like C:\Dev\tauris-skills. That is only a placeholder. Nothing requires the C:\ drive root or a folder named Dev. Put the repo and the skills inside your own user profile, which every Windows account can write to without admin rights.

Throughout this guide, %USERPROFILE% means your personal folder, normally C:\Users\<your-name>. You can type %USERPROFILE% directly into the Windows Explorer address bar or a Command Prompt and it expands automatically.

Locked-down machine? If you have no admin rights and cannot write to C:\, you can still install all four skills. Only native PHDWin .phz extraction (Section 4) needs an admin-installed driver — and SQLite-based review works without it.

3. Install the skills (lowest-friction path)

This copies four self-contained skill folders into Cowork's skills directory. Cowork auto-discovers any SKILL.md it finds there on startup — there is no install command to run.

Step 1 — Put the repo somewhere you can write

Copy or clone the tauris-skills repo into your user profile, for example:

%USERPROFILE%\tauris-skills
(e.g. C:\Users\jsmith\tauris-skills)

If you are offline, just copy the folder over by USB or network share — there is nothing to download or build for the skills.

Step 2 — Copy the four skill folders

Copy each **whole skill folder** (the folder containing SKILL.md plus its references/ and scripts/) into:

%USERPROFILE%\\.claude\skills\

If the .claude\skills folders do not exist yet, create them. The four skills to copy are:

Skill folder (in the repo)	Copies to
areas\aries\skills\aries-core	.claude\skills\aries-core\
areas\aries\skills\aries-ac-economic	.claude\skills\aries-ac-economic\
areas\phdwin-v2\skills\phdwin-v2-querying	.claude\skills\phdwin-v2-querying\
areas\petroleum-economics\skills\petroleum-economics-review	.claude\skills\petroleum-economics-review\

When finished you should have, for example, %USERPROFILE%\\.claude\skills\aries-core\SKILL.md and the same pattern for the other three.

Step 3 — Restart Cowork

Fully quit and reopen Claude Cowork. On startup it scans the skills directory and registers any skill it finds. No further setup is needed.

Step 4 — Confirm they loaded

Ask Cowork to list its skills, or start a request that should trigger one — for example:

Use the ARIES core skill. Summarize the standard PHDWin-to-Aries review workflow and the key target tables.

If it responds using the skill's content, the install worked.

One caveat (not a blocker) aries-core references its sibling skills with relative paths like ../aries-ac-economic/SKILL.md. Flattening the folders into .claude\skills\ breaks those exact links. They are lazy "load when needed" pointers, so each skill still triggers and works on its own — the agent just can't auto-follow those specific paths. Fine for testing; worth knowing.

4. Optional — Install the PHDWin v2 MCP server

Only needed if you want the PHDWin inspection / PHDWin-to-Aries review tools. Skip this section if you only need the skills.

4.1 Requirements

- Windows machine running Claude Cowork.
- Python with the fastmcp package (and pyodbc for database access).
- For native PHDWin .phz / .phd / .mod extraction only: the 32-bit Clarion/TopSpeed ODBC driver. This usually needs admin to install.
- For SQLite-only review: **no driver required**. Most users work from a SQLite review database and never need the Clarion driver.

4.2 Install check

Open Command Prompt and run each line. (The 32-bit launcher is used because the Clarion driver is typically 32-bit.)

```
py -3.12-32 --version
py -3.12-32 -c "import pyodbc, fastmcp; print('pyodbc', pyodbc.version); print('fastmcp ok')"
py -3.12-32 -c "import pyodbc; [print(d) for d in pyodbc.drivers()]"
```

If fastmcp is missing, install it with `py -3.12-32 -m pip install fastmcp pyodbc`. The Clarion/TopSpeed driver only needs to appear in the third command's output if you intend to extract native PHDWin files.

4.3 Add the server to Cowork's config

In Cowork: **Settings → Developer → Edit Config**. Merge in the block below.

Required edit Change the script path to wherever you actually put the repo. Use your own user folder — **not** C:/Dev. Use forward slashes.

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "phdwin-v2": {
      "command": "py",
      "args": [
        "-3.12-32",
        "C:/Users/<your-name>/tauris-skills/areas/phdwin-v2/mcp-servers/PHDWinv2_MCP/scripts/
phdwin_mcp_server.py"
      ]
    }
  }
}
```

If your config already has an mcpServers section, add only the phdwin-v2 entry inside it rather than pasting the whole block.

4.4 Restart and verify

Fully restart Cowork. Then return to **Settings → Developer** and confirm phdwin-v2 appears in the local MCP server list. First prompt to test it:

Use the phdwin-v2 MCP server. Run `env_check` and tell me whether this machine is ready to query native PHDWin v2 files for PHDWin-to-Aries conversion.

5. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
Skills don't appear after restart	Confirm the path is %USERPROFILE%\.claude\skills\<skill>\SKILL.md (the SKILL.md must be directly inside the skill folder). Fully quit and reopen Cowork.
Can't write to C:\	You don't need to. Use %USERPROFILE% — your own user folder is always writable.
phdwin-v2 not in MCP list	Check the script path in the config is correct and uses forward slashes, then fully restart Cowork.
Clarion/TopSpeed driver not found	Only needed for native .phz extraction. Either install the 32-bit driver (admin) or work from a SQLite review database, which needs no driver.
64-bit vs 32-bit Python mismatch	The Clarion driver is 32-bit; a 64-bit Python can't see it. Install a 32-bit Python side-by-side and use the py -3.12-32 launcher flag.

Repo: github.com/Tauris-AI/tauris-skills · Skills install needs no admin, no Python, no special drive.